

PBS Utah Business Problem Statement

Business Problem

In July 2025, Congress eliminated \$1.1 billion in previously approved federal funding for public broadcasting, increasing financial pressure on public media organizations such as PBS Utah. With an annual budget shortfall of approximately \$2 million, PBS Utah is seeking opportunities to increase private donor support. Major donors represent only about 1% of PBS Utah's donor file but have generated approximately 19% of donor revenue, making identifying and developing additional major donors an important fundraising opportunity.

PBS Utah has extensive historical data on donations, campaigns, membership, University of Utah relationships, capacity, engagement, and PBS Passport viewing activity, but lacks a systematic way to combine these data to identify constituents with the potential to increase their giving. This project will use the available data to identify constituents with potential annual giving between \$2,000 and \$15,000, allowing the Major Gifts team to focus its limited fundraising and stewardship resources on the most promising prospects.

Benefits of a Solution

A successful solution would help PBS Utah identify new fundraising opportunities by finding constituents with the potential to increase their annual giving and expanding the major-gift pipeline below the University of Utah's existing \$25,000 threshold. By combining donation history, campaign response, capacity ratings, university relationships, and viewing engagement, PBS Utah can make better use of its existing data to identify promising prospects and better understand their giving behavior and interests.

The solution would allow development officers to prioritize prospects based on analytical evidence rather than manually reviewing the entire donor database, reducing time spent evaluating constituents who are less likely to increase their giving. It would also establish a repeatable prospect-identification process that can be refreshed as new data become available. The analysis is intended to support human fundraising decisions, while decisions regarding who to contact, how to approach them, and how much to request would remain with PBS Utah's fundraising professionals.

Success Metrics

The project will be considered successful if PBS Utah can use the resulting analysis to identify and prioritize actionable donor segments for fundraising outreach. Success will be evaluated based on the analysis's ability to distinguish current major donors, identify constituents with increased giving potential, and recognize meaningful changes in giving behavior.

- **Major Donor Identification:** Identify and categorize constituents who currently contribute more than \$1,200 annually based on their historical giving behavior.

- **Major Donor Potential:** Identify and prioritize lower-level donors whose giving history, capacity, engagement, and other constituent characteristics indicate potential to increase their annual giving, particularly within the \$2,000 to \$15,000 target range.
- **Giving Growth:** Identify constituents demonstrating meaningful year-over-year increases in annual giving as an additional indicator of future giving potential.

Analytics Approach

We will analyze historical giving patterns to segment constituents based on annual giving, donation frequency, campaign participation, membership history and other relevant characteristics. This will establish profiles of current major donors and we can find patterns that associate with higher donation amounts.

Major donor potential modeling: Use constituent characteristics, including donation history, U of U relationships, campaign response and engagement etc. to develop a predictive model that estimates a potential to increase their giving. The analysis will focus on potential annual giving in the \$2,000-\$15,000 range.

Finally, we will combine the strongest indicators from the analysis into an interpretable prospect framework and dashboard. The dashboard will allow PBS Utah team to filter and explore donor segments, examine the factors contributing to a constituent's potential, identify donor increasing trends and prioritize prospects for human review in the future.

Scope

The primary deliverable is an interactive dashboard that uses historical donation, constituent, and engagement data to identify current major donors and constituents with the potential to increase their annual giving. PBS Utah will use these insights to prioritize fundraising outreach and support donor cultivation efforts. Determining the specific solicitation strategy, donor benefits, event invitations, gifts, or other cultivation methods used for individual constituents is outside the primary scope of the analysis.

Details

The project work will be carried out by the student analytics team over the Fall 2026 Semester, with a presentation of our findings to be given during the to-be-assigned timeslot (either December 2nd or 9th). Historical constituent, donation, membership, engagement, and related PBS Utah data will be used for the analysis. The final deliverable will include an interactive dashboard and actionable recommendations for identifying and prioritizing donors for fundraising outreach.